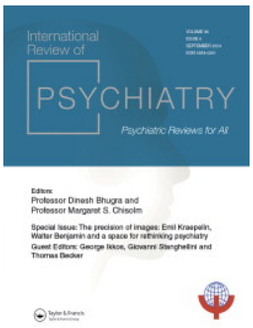

International Review of Psychiatry

ISSN: 0954-0261 (Print) 1369-1627 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/iirp20

Radical social theorists Antonio Gramsci and Walter Benjamin: can they help understand and power effective mental health reform?

Thomas Becker, Tobias Müller, George Ikkos & Sven Speerforck

To cite this article: Thomas Becker, Tobias Müller, George Ikkos & Sven Speerforck (2024) Radical social theorists Antonio Gramsci and Walter Benjamin: can they help understand and power effective mental health reform?, International Review of Psychiatry, 36:6, 626-638, DOI: 10.1080/09540261.2024.2364846

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/09540261.2024.2364846

© 2024 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

Published online: 08 Jun 2024.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 2040

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Citing articles: 4 View citing articles

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=iirp20

INTERNATIONAL REVIEW OF PSYCHIATRY
2024, VOL. 36, NO. 6, 626–638
https://doi.org/10.1080/09540261.2024.2364846

Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group

REVIEW ARTICLE

OPEN ACCESS Check for updates

Radical social theorists Antonio Gramsci and Walter Benjamin: can they help understand and power effective mental health reform?

Thomas Becker[a], Tobias Müller[b], George Ikkos[c] and Sven Speerforck[a]

[a]Department of Psychiatry, University of Leipzig Medical Center, Leipzig, Germany; [b]Department of Political and Communication Science, University of Greifswald, Greifswald, Germany; [c]Department of Liaison Psychiatry, Royal National Orthopaedic Hospital NHS Trust, Stanmore, UK

ABSTRACT

Issues concerning the relationship between psychiatrists and people with experience of mental ill health and implications for psychiatric reform are covered. Antonio Gramsci (1891-1937), Italian politician and Marxist philosopher, focused on the concepts of culture, hegemony and common sense in analysing societal change. He can be credited with having provided a concept for the role intellectuals can assume in processes of change. Gramsci contributed to the concept of 'hegemony'. It can be argued that he provided some theoretical background to the Italian psychiatric reform leading to a new mental health law in 1978. Walter Benjamin (1892-1940), German literary and cultural critic, understood cultural change as an integral part of history as it unfolds. His magnum opus, the Arcades Project, describes Paris as the capital of the 19th century. Benjamin's thinking can be considered complementary with Gramsci's work in analysing society by focusing on physical structure, technology, images, media and culture. His work focuses on 'experience'. Benjamin's perspective on society may help to understand mental health issues such as therapeutic encounter or peer support. Gramsci provides a framework for understanding psychiatric reform as part of societal change. Both thinkers can help understand how mental health reform is related with society.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 26 April 2024
Accepted 3 June 2024

KEYWORDS
Antonio gramsci; walter benjamin; mental health reform; psychiatric reform; peer support

Introduction

How are we to think about psychiatrists as an elite social group and our relationship with the much larger social group of people with experience of mental ill health conditions, and what are the implications for formulating and ensuring effective public mental health and services reform? And how might we think differently to do better?

In a book on Franco Basaglia who was the charismatic leader of the Italian psychiatric reform, John Foot (2015) embeds the mental health reform project that started in the mental health institution (or asylum) of Gorizia in North East Italy within the wider context of European student (and worker) protest movements of 1968 (and the preceding and following years). Critical reform psychiatry, in Foot's book, is seen as part of a wider critical movement in Western societies. Foot (2015) argues that the Italian reforming psychiatrists (of Psichiatria Democratica) came close to Antonio Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual' through engaging with social and cultural change processes. It could be argued that these psychiatrists were the first group of intellectuals choosing to enter into dialogue with the wider student movement, accepting it as partner for the transmission of their ideas and as a motivator adding political weight to their activities.

The movement explicitly criticized 'total institutions' as discussed in Erving Goffman's book 'Asylums' (Goffman, 1990). The critique reached beyond mental hospitals and included other institutions such as military organisations, prisons etc. In the year that finally saw the Italian Parliament's Psychiatric Reform Law N. 180/1978 (and also the first Italian abortion law, indicating a broader climate of societal reform), there was a debate whether the law corresponded to the original intentions of the reformers or whether it had gone through a process of 'watering down'.

CONTACT Thomas Becker Thomas.Becker@medizin.uni-leipzig.de Department of Psychiatry, University of Leipzig Medical Center, Semmelweisstraße 10, Leipzig 04103, Germany
© 2024 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group
This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

The parliamentary process leading to both houses of Parliament passing Law 180 in May 1978 evolved under the pressure of a Radical Party referendum initiative that threatened to deprive the country of all mental health legislation. Thus, the process was hurried. Referring to that process, Franco Basaglia explicitly mentioned Antonio Gramsci in saying: 'As democratic psychiatrists, we spurred on this law. We are in a minority, but, as Gramsci once said, we are a hegemonic minority' (Foot, 2015, p 381). There is also extensive material reflecting reference to Gramsci and the role of the intellectual within Psichiatria Democatica published in Italian (and only partially translated into French and German) (Basaglia & Basaglia-Ongaro, 1975/1980; Colucci & Di Vittorio, 2001; Leoni, 2011; Peloso, 2023). It also needs saying that, in Basaglia's writing, reference to Sartre was more prominent than to Gramsci. Gramsci's thinking (as referred to in Basaglia and colleagues' discourse) was filtered through the work of Italian anthropologist, ethnologist and philosopher Ernesto de Martino (Pieraccini, 2006).

The context of wider anti-institutional debates in the political-cultural climate of 1968 and in the decade that followed has been confirmed by other authors. According to Lumley (Lumley, 1983), oppositional movements of the decade of 1968-1978 included the trade union and student movement but extended to a wider range of activities, i.e. urban struggles, the feminist movement, youth counter-culture, others linked to sexuality, regional issues, consumer protest, ecological issues, neo-religious and communitarian ideas, as well as anti-institutional protests (justice system, prisons, psychiatric hospitals, health and health care issues). This analysis confirms that mental health reform, across Europe, was one example of a much wider process of political, social and cultural change.

In an even wider context, and bearing in mind earlier criticism of psychiatric institutions (Weiss, 2011), the period of widespread trans-national institutional criticism of psychiatry and mental health reform (from the late 1950s to about 1990) coincides with a reshaping of critical thought in Western societies that points away from the potential for change residing in 'working class masses' and heads towards reformulations of societal change focusing on language and culture, psychology, communicative rationality and the public sphere (e.g. Habermas), commodity aesthetics (e.g. Haug, 2017), subalternity (e.g. Spivak, 1988), and diversity. Some of these concepts referred to (older) theorists such as Gramsci with his emphasis on education and the potential for reform inherent in cultural movements, and Walter Benjamin with his emphasis on a materialist theory of history based on a sensual reading of 19th century history prefiguring the (20th century) present. Both Gramsci and Benjamin, in the second half of the 20th century, were seen as relevant thinkers in the post-WW II context of the gradual disappearance of what had once been an industrial working class and dogmatic Marxist theories of societal change having lost their attraction. Also relevant here were the Frankfurt School (Horkheimer, Adorno) and Jürgen Habermas, a theorist of communicative rationality and discursive ethics providing new perspectives on modernity and reform.

Against this wider background, this article asks whether theoretical contributions by Antonio Gramsci (1891-1937) and Walter Benjamin (1892-1940) are relevant to the fields of mental health and mental health reform today. The question is asked whether the writings of these two intellectuals can contribute to the analysis of mental health issues and mental health reform today. Gramsci's and Benjamin's thinking must be revisited against a widely differing historical background. Gramsci's systematised approach may appear particularly distant while Benjamin's thinking is looser which may ease the 'incoummensurability' from a 21st century present. However, we argue that Gramsci's and Benjamin's thinking may have relevance in widely different circumstances today, and the present article will attempt to explore this potential. In the discussion we reflect on these questions in the context of wider 'Critical Theory', including the Frankfurt School of Social Research, of which Benjamin was a peripheral member.

Materials and methods

The following text is based on a (selective) reading of an English-language selection of Antonio Gramsci's wiritings (Forgacs, 2000) and of some of the literature on Gramsci (Fontana, 1993; Francese, 2009; Pizzolato & Holst, 2017). It is also based on a selective, non-systematic reading of some of Walter Benjamin's texts, the reading process being guided by an initial reading of Walter Benjamin's magnum opus, the Arcades Project (Becker and Hoff, this issue; Benjamin, 1999). No systematic literature search was performed. The literature published in Italian on the reading and significance of Gramsci's work within the Italian psychiatric reform movement of the 1970s and 1980s (Basaglia & Basaglia-Ongaro, 1975/1980; Colucci & Di Vittorio, 2001) is not referred to. The reading of the literature is, therefore, very selective and restricted to the literature available to English-speaking scholars.

Results

Antonio Gramsci: short biographical sketch

Antonio Gramsci, born on the island of Sardinia in 1891, won a scholarship to study at the University of Turin (reading literature), a centre of Italian industrialisation, and was involved in the workers' movement there, became a member of the Italian Socialist Party and, later, a founding member and leading figure of the Communist Party (PCI) and was arrested in Fascist Italy in 1926. He wrote extensively during imprisonment and died in 1937.

Gramsci's work

In the sections of his selected writings summarized in the following paragraphs, Gramsci developed a range of concepts (hegemony, organic intellectual, senso comune, historic and cultural bloc) that may help to better understand what is required in complex social and professional systems to achieve innovation, institutional reform and social change, e.g. in the field of mental health care.

Section VI hegemony, relations of force, historical bloc

Gramsci is well-known for his contributions to the concept of 'hegemony' (Anderson & Jakubzik, 2018; Fontana, 1993). This concept is outlined in Part Two of his Prison Writings of 1929-1935 (Forgacs, 2000). Gramsci started writing the prison notebooks (late 1920s) during a period which had seen, in countries other than Russia, defeat and failure of socialist revolutions and the stabilisation of capitalist economies in the course of the 1920s. Gramsci discerned a lack of an adequate Marxist theory of the 'state' and of political, legal, and cultural systems. In going back to Marx' *Preface to A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy* he argued that socio-economic circumstances did not 'of themselves' produce political change but that they set the conditions in which change became possible. Gramsci also deals with the concept of 'error' (individual impulses, mistaken calculations, manifestations of attempts of specific groups or sects), a topic that had been ignored in what he labels as mechanical historical materialism.

He argues that, in political theory, insufficient attention has been given to the fact that political acts may be due primarily to internal necessities of an organisational character, and that these are tied to the needs of social organisations such as parties, groups, or societies. Structures (of social relations of production) and superstructures, in Gramsci's understanding, form what he called a 'historical bloc'. Superstructures may be complex, contradictory and discordant, and the interplay of mutual relationships (of structure and superstructure) can be described as a dialectical process. Gramsci's 'philosophy of praxis' conceives the relationship of structure and superstructures as intertwined and reciprocal.

Given the fact that orthodox Marxism with its economic determinism was not able to cope with then recent developments in Western Europe, Gramsci's philosophy of praxis emphasises the importance of cultural facts, of cultural activity, of a 'cultural front' alongside economic and political campaigns. Thus, he confers a positive role on 'organic ideologies' that help to organise political thought and action (with popular convictions, according to Marx, having the same energy as material forces). Mankind, according to Gramsci, will set itself only such tasks as it is able to solve which implies, however, that special challenges are likely to arise when material conditions constitute both the problem and (potential for) its solutions. Gramsci argues that economic crises do not 'produce' historical events but can create a terrain favourable to the dissemination of specific lines of thought. There is, in Gramsci's opinion, no mechanical deterministic mode of economic forces impacting at the socio-cultural-political level. Accordingly, he argues that the beginning of the French revolution 'occurred in the context of conflicts on a higher plane than the immediate world of the economy' (Forgacs, 2000).

Gramsci argued that, during crises of ruling class hegemony and/or in situations of mass popular protest, there will be attempts, with the support of intellectual, scientific or technical elites, to reabsorb the control slipping from ruling-class grasp. What then happens will depend on the degree of organic (or charismatic) organisation that has been achieved by the forces opposing ruling-class hegemony. Gramsci discusses the sources of political leverage of political parties representing the broad masses. (A note of caution: there are wide-ranging differences between the world that Gramsci wrote about compared to present-day societies. The 'masses', in contemporary society, are different, and their relations to the state and mass media are different.) Analyses of such situations of political crisis, according to Gramsci, need to take into account: the social group basis of different political groups; their mass membership; their bureacracay; and their general staff. Gramsci suggests to use this type of analysis to understand the failures of German or French left-of-centre parties in the face of fascism.

Section X intellectuals and education

'I greatly extend the notion of intellectuals', Gramsci wrote in a letter in 1931 (Forgacs, 2000). Gramsci's definition of intellectuals includes anyone whose function in society is primarily that of organising, administering, directing, educating or leading others. His interest in intellectuals is likely to have arisen from his early writings on education (see Section II in Forgacs (2000)) and from his non-economistic conception of a 'historical bloc'. For the working class to challenge the economic and political order and become hegemonic in its turn, it needed to create 'organic' intellectuals of its own. The party, for Gramsci, functions as a 'collective intellectual', and needs to influence education both inside and outside party bodies. There are several types of intellectuals such as, e.g. the industrial technicians, specialists in political economy, the organisers of a new culture, or of a new legal system. Categories of intellectuals include the ecclesiastics who, for a long time, have held a monopoly of some important services (religious ideology, philosophy, science of the age, schools, education, morality, justice, charity, good works, etc.). According to Gramsci, they were organically bound to the landed aristocracy. Monarchy also developed a number of complementary or competing intellectuals ('noblesse de robe', scholars, scientists, theorists, non-ecclesiastical philosophers, etc.). Gramsci thought that, in further inquiry, it was through cultural history and the history of political science that researchers and practitioners would be better placed to understand these intellectual groups. He was striving for a functional understanding of the category of 'intellectuals' ('All men are intellectuals, one could therefore say; but not all men have in society the function of intellectuals …', Forgacs (2000, p 304)). Gramsci considered that the activities around education he was observing in contemporary society emphasised the role of the educational system in societal change processes. He assumed a strategic role for educated, technical-intellectual elites (Pizzolato & Holst, 2017).

Gramsci also defined two major superstructural 'levels': one called 'civil society', i.e. the ensemble of organisms called 'private' (familial, informal), and that of the 'political society' or 'state'. These two levels, according to Gramsci, constitute the arena in which the 'hegemony' of dominant societal groups is exerted. The state and government constitute what Gramsci calls 'direct domination' or command. He also descibes an 'esprit de corps' among the various levels of intellectuals. The democratic-bureaucratic system has led to an unprecedented expansion of this group in society. He distinguishes urban (industry-linked) and rural (lawyers, notaries, etc.) intellectuals. Political parties, in Gramsci's view, '… are responsible for welding together the organic intellectuals of a given group – the dominant one – and the traditional intellectuals' (Forgacs, 2000). To him, all members of a political party could be considered as intellectuals (in that they organise political thinking and action, i.e. are involved in directive, organisational, and educational activities).

Section XI philosophy, common sense, language and folklore

Gramsci's intent, in this scetion, is to deal with the separation beteween Marxism as a philosophy (the 'philosophy of praxis') and people's actual consciousness. Forgacs (2000) argues that Gramsci does not conceive of Marxism as imposing itself mechanically from the outside, but prefers the image of Marxism drawing out and evolving elements of critical awareness and 'good sense' that are already present within what is considered people's 'common sense' (senso comune). In that line of thought, the philosophy of praxis can exert a certain leverage on people's consciousness since a part of that 'consciousness' is already aware of its truth. In this way, a struggle of 'hegemonies' can take place. In this logic, in order to shilft people's common sense, the philosophy of praxis (Marxism) must engage with what 'the common people' actually think. According to Gramsci, there is a serious lack within Marxist theory of a critique systematically arguing with and getting involved with 'common sense'. The concept of hegemony that Gramsci formulated was influenced by concepts in historical linguistics ('prestige', 'radiation of innovations'). He also considers the detail of how religious and cultural concepts are formulated and organised in their relation to both the elite and 'simple people'. He considers how intellectuals should address the problems raised by the masses in their practical day-to-day activities, and this could help constitute what Gramsci calls a 'cultural and social bloc'. This development could go towards elaborating a form of thought superior to 'common sense' and coherent on a scientific level, and it would still remain in contact with 'simple people' and find the source of the problems it sets out to study and resolve. Gramsci, in developing his thought, takes into account contradictions in intellectual consciousness and 'man-in-the-mass consciousness'. The 'simple man' /woman may have two theoretical consciousnesses (or one contradictory

consciousness): one implicit in his (or her) activity and uniting him (or her) with all his (or her) fellow-workers in the practical transformation of the reald world; and another one, superficially explicit or verbal, which he (or she) has inherited from the past and has uncritically absorbed. The ultimate aim of this process (involving organic intellectuals and the 'masses') can be called the concept of the unity of theory and practice (Forgacs, 2000, p 333/334). Political parties, in Gramsci's conception, are the elaborators of new integral and comprehensive intelligentsias (with the unification of theory and practice conceived of as a historical process). The idea is one of 'intellectuals arising out of the masses' (Forgacs, 2000, p 340). Of course, newspapers, magazines and other forms of mass communication are important in this process. Gramsci's thinking moves in the direction of a concept of 'cultural policy'.

Walter Benjamin: short biographical sketch

Walter Benjamin, born in Berlin in 1892, grew up in the city, studied at the Universities of Freiburg, Berlin, Munich and Berne (reading philosophy), successfuly defended his PhD thesis at Berne University and subsequently worked as a literary and cultural critic. He was a well-known literary critic during the Weimar Republic, emigrated in 1933 and lived in Paris (traveling extensively). He received financial support from the Frankfurt Institute of Social Research, which had then moved to the USA, continued his literary work and, finally, committed suicide at the French-Spanish border during his flight from Nazi-occupied France, in 1940.

Benjamin's work

The relationship between the phenomena (of the material, sensual world) and the world of ideas is central to Benjamin's thinking. The empirical world, moving through images, dissolves in the world of ideas. His concept of resonance or similitude in the encounter of present and past leading to moments of recognition or 'dialectical images' (Ikkos & Stanghellini, this issue), with the past exploding into now-time, could be useful in the attempt to understand therapeutic encounter, moments of jointly deciphering individual experience and of embedding experience in its wider cultural context. We could hypothesise that Benjamin developed a 'language' to describe the concept of experience, of 'encounter' and of 'moments of discovery' in (psychotherapeutic or other) relationships.

Jan Loheit (2019), in a chapter in Voigt et al. (2019), describes how Walter Benjamin discussed cultural issues in the light of their socio-economic context. Benjamin's idea was that literary science required Marxist input but needed to be close to sensual data. In this context, Loheit briefly refers to the work of Gramsci who, according to Loheit (2019), had formulated a critique of mechanistic formalism in Marxism reminiscent of Benjamin's approach. However, while Gramsci emphasised cultural debate and education, it was Benjamin who delved into the issues in greater detail, exploring concepts such as ideas, experience and memory, and how they relate to the material world (with some blurring or erasing, in Benjamin's writing, of boundaries between the experiencing self and the material world).

To Benjamin, the commodity character of objects (in the modern marketplace) and 'commodity fetishism' were key concepts in developing his line of literary criticism. As summarised by Morgan (this issue) human work processes are conceived as transformed into things. Reification is the result of commodified capitalism. The relation of the worker to his or her product is transformed from a process of creation to a process with the object being disconnected from the labour invested in it. As commodity it comes to stand outside the worker, as both the property of another, and as an item of exchange. Everything is measured in terms of its value for exchange.

Benjamin held that technical and material aspects in the world of things were important in 'reading' history. To Benjamin, the physical and sensual character of the world was important in understanding the flow of history. In this context, Marxist dramatist Bertolt Brecht and social and cultural theorists Georg Lukacs and Karl Korsch were of importance to Benjamin's thinking. The Arcades Project, his unfinished magnum opus, reflected Benjamin's historic-materialist concept of nature and history with an emphasis on the physical and material world (and focusing, in particular, on the city of Paris as the 'capital of the 19th century'). Nature was considered profoundly shaped by human societal action or as 'societal matter'. What humans may know about history is 'bound' to the specific historical and material context. Benjamin's formulation was one of economic conditions finding 'expression in" society and not mechanically 'determining' an ideological 'superstructure' as dogmatic Marxists had argued. Reflecting the commodity character of the material world Benjamin thought that material objects could be seen as 'transfigured' or 'phantasmagorias'. Film as a new art form is referred to by Loheit (2019) as an example of Benjamin's

interest in formal technical and aesthetic qualities of new media that influence human perception. To Benjamin, the 'material' aspects of observation took precedence over theory, and by describing material things in their complexity socio-economic foundations would become obvious. Benjamin wanted to see literary science grounded in historical materiality.

Meiffert (2017) discusses Walter Benjamin's methods in cultural criticism. 'Wahrheit' or truth, so believed Benjamin, was related to the spirit of an artwork. Terms used by Benjamin to describe his method of criticisam comprise: Ursprungswissenschaft (science of origin), constructive anamnesis, dialectics in a standstill and something he calls 'micrology' (Mikrologie), a science of the 'minimal' or 'minute'. His idea was that highly singular, odd or idiosyncratic phenomena could help discover the essence or 'constellation of truth'. There is cross-talk here with Adorno's concept of 'constellations 'that can help understand or decipher objects or phenomena (as developed in Negative Dialektik of 1969). Rather than enumerating or adding up 'qualities' this builds on the recognition of the 'constellation' or Gestalt of phenomena.

In examining whether 'micrology' aptly describes Benjamin's working method Meiffert, in his paper, refers to three texts by Benjamin (The Origin of the German Mourning Play 1925, Berlin Childhood 1933-1938, and Arcades Project 1938-1940). In the epistemological prologue of 'The Origin of the German Mourning Play' (1925) Benjamin argued that 'consciousness' or 'conscious thinking' must help in the process of truth 'expounding itself' . Consciousness is about striving for cognitive statements. Truth, according to Benjamin, is 'unity in being' and cannot be clarified through question and answer. In Benjamin's thinking the act of understanding is about detail. The quest for 'truth' is about contemplation and observation. The 'mosaic' and 'micrology' are considered tools on the path toward 'determining truth'. Benjamin considered that a certain 'Gestalt' would materialise both in single elements of a (natural) whole and in its entirety/totality.

Similar to Plato, Benjamin considered 'ideas' as pre-existing entities. All understanding refers to the empirical world only. The empirical world, according to Benjamin, 'dissolves' in the world of ideas (Ideenwelt). Abstractions lend the phenomena their share of being 'ideas'. The world of ideas relates to things the same way as constellations of stars relate to (individual) stars. Constructive anamnesis, in Benjamin's thinking, helps define a path between inductive and deductive thinking, and he emphasised the historicity of ideas. The restoration or reconstruction of phenomena (via ideas) is intertwined with an emphasis on what is incomplete. Phenomena define the rules that express their constellation or configurative order. Benjamin gave up the idea of a 'complete' configuration of history or truth. Dialectics-at-a-standstill presents the idea of flash-like constellations in 'now-time' that define landmarks of the historical process. The concept is of 'ideas' being 'monads' (Leibniz). Ideas and monads contain 'the image of the world' in what is considered an incomplete picture. According to what Benjmain calls 'micrological truth', the monads/ideas have the 'picture of the whole' somehow inscribed in them.

Benjamin, in the prologue of the German Mourning Play book, formulated 'micrology' as a theory of understanding or truth. His (auto)biographical texts, such as his Berlin Childhood texts, concentrated on subjectivity and experience. Truth, to Benjamin, resides in the formation, the coming-into-being or the history of phenomena. Individual items of experience (Erlebnisse, related to phenomena) inter-connect to constitute experience (Erfahrung). Imagination helps identify patterns of infinitely small things that form constellations. This quality is referred to, by Benjamin, as 'mimetic capacity' which is a key to the experience of childhood. The origin of identity, according to Benjamin, is closely related to what he calls a 'Gestalt-Switch'. Gestalt-Switches or moments of 'self-realisation' are connected with scare or fright. Child play leads to discovery, and there are moments of self-liberation and scare or fright (Schreck). To Benjamin, disparate elements converge into configurations. There is a seal of authenticity which confirms the closeness with the original phenomena. The core of subjective personhood, to Benjamin, is identical with the 'inner world of things'. Benjamin's interest is in 'constellations' that evolve into 'larger constellations'. The difference between object and image is dissolved in Benjamin, and relationships between these worlds can be seen as temporal relations.

Walter Benjamin developed a theory of *experience*. He described 'false mimesis' as a phenomenon resembling phantasmagoria. Memory will notice the content of false mimesis or phantasmagoria giving rise to 'shock experiences' ('Chockerlebnisse'). Such experience may lead to 'impaired or damaged' subjectivity. Benjamin considers the perception of similitude, in looking to the past, as flash-like or lighning-like. Thus, the past passes by or scurries past. Benjamin's understanding posits a moment of (potential) recognition of the past in any one moment of present time (now-time, Jetzt-Zeit) with recognition being tied to the discovery of 'resonance, similitude or sense' in the encounter of present and past. There is a moment of

'recognisability' in this theory of the relationship between past and present. The writing of history by historical materialism, in Benjamin's terms, is linked with 'awakening the suppressed past'. Again, here is the thought that, in the detail, the overall Gestalt of an epoch and (aspects of) overall history become apparent over time. Discontinuous moments of past and now-time evolving into images-in-a-standstill will help to describe individual and societal history. This, in Benjamin's view, leads to moments of 'awakening'. The dialectical image is a 'micrological' constellation that, in passing through successive moments of now-time, expresses societal inter-subjectivity.

Meiffert (Meiffert, 2017) uses the image of the unique number combination opening a safe to illustrate Benjamin's highly personal understanding of how history can be understood and 'jump' into the present. The 'not-yet-conscious', in Benjamin's thinking, can combine with the process of re-connaissance. This could be called remembrance (or the present resonating with a glimpse from the past). And it is in this process that Benjamin identifies a glimpse of hope.

Discussion

Reforms of mental health care: designed or happening?

How may the above relate to mental health care, both historically and in thinking about the future? Psychiatric (or mental health) reform processes are specific phases in the overall development of the institutions and processes of mental health care, and they can be studied as phases in the development of the psychiatric profession and of related professions, mental health care being a multidisciplinary undertaking (Becker & Fangerau, 2018; Bhugra et al., 2011). This pespective highlights the importance of professionals and their leverage in mental health care and mental health reform. A related aspect is that of the psychiatric profession having to deal with social issues (poverty, marginalisation, stigma, social control) and structural inequalities. The 1960s were characterised, In industrialised countries, by an intense debate both on social issues relevant to mental health and on professional roles, a debate reminiscent of Max Weber's discussion of the roles of scientific and political elites (as professions) at the end of World War I (Weber, 2015, 2018).

Some of Gramsci's thought on (traditional and organic) intellectuals is highly relevant to the themes of professions and professional roles both then and today. Gramsci classified intellectuals '… either as traditional intellectuals or as organic intellectuals. […] Organic intellectuals […] are more directly related to the economic structure of their society simply because of the fact that every social group that originates in the fulfillment of an essential task of economic production creates its own organic intellectual. Thus, the organic intellectual gives his class homogeneity and awareness of its own function, in the economic field and on the social and political levels' (Ramos, 1982). In any struggle for social hegememony (so goes the argument) these organic intellectuals must reason with the masses and engage in a decisive 'war of position' to consolidate the hegemonic status of the class the interests of which they share' (Ramos, 1982). This implies that members of an elite are free to join a reformist movement and that weight must be given to the cultural sphere of ideas in bringing about social change. Here is a line of thought that may help to better understand processes of psychiatric reform such as the Italian mental health reform of the 1960s to 1980s.

We need to bear in mind that, with socio-economic, scientific and technological change, the number of intellectuals (as defined by Gramsci) has increased since. Also, the incomes of intellectuals (i.e. the more educated) have increased (by 40% in the US), in contrast with those of low education which have decreased (by 20% in the US) (Acemoglu & Restrepo, 2021). Thus, an increasing separation has occured between intellectuals and the (no longer working class) 'masses'. This raises the question of whether intellectuals can adopt a hegemonic position in relation to the 'masses' today, e.g. in working with service users (and whether that analogy still holds). Psychiatrists may not have the same relation to the population they serve as would doctors or teachers in Gramsci's (or Franco Basaglia's) time.

The organic intellectual in psychiatric history: Franco Basaglia and the Italian reform

Richard Mollica, in a paper published in 1985, outlined the sociopolitical concepts and psychiatric strategies underlying Western Europe's most radical psychiatric reform movement in Italy, i.e. Psichiatria Democratica. The author argued that little attention had been given to the influence of Italy's major political theorist of the 20th century, Antonio Gramsci, on the Italian reformers and on Franco Basaglia, their leader (Mollica, 1985). Mollica argued that Gramsci's theory of 'hegemony' which he elaborated in his Prison notebooks, was very relevant to Italian psychiatric reform. The aim of the Italian reformers was to build a movement that would span all levels of the social structure from the level of governement to the interpersonal sphere. Mollica (1985) points to the

rejection of eonomic determinism by Gramsci and to his rejection of models of change based on a simplistic unidimensional analysis of class struggle. Gramsci and Basaglia, so writes Mollica, had a project of cultural transformation in mind, something that Gramsci referred to when he reflected on the 'Modern Prince' (a term used for the Communist Party, in his prison notebooks). The aim of the psychiatric reformers was to dismantle the repressive structure of psychiatric institutions. Gramsci's theory of hegemony had moved away from economic reductionism, seeking a more comprehensive explanation accounting for patterns of social behaviour and institutional practices. Thus, hegemony is about the understanding and modification of meanings, value systems and practices, and it is often contradictory in nature. Gramsci clearly moved away from a one-to-one relationship between ruling classes and society's ruling ideas. Organisatons such as the church, trade unions, schools and orgnisations in the arts, literature, and academia were important to him. Individuals use their 'common sense' (senso comune, a Gramscian term) to respond to the exigencies of their social contexts. Gramsci argued that subordinate groups in society were able, under special cirucmstances, to reassert their essential interests. Mollica (1985) argues that this vision of oppressed individuals shifting society's hegemony to a new moral order was important for the Italian psychiatric reform movement. In what Gramsci called a 'war of position' or 'trench warfare', reformers could seize opportunities to reveal (and hopefully overcome) the contradictions in society underlying the repressive social (and psychiatric) structures. In creating counter-hegemony, Gramsci saw room for political, intellectual, and moral leadership, and he defined as a new group of 'organic intellectuals' those who were more closely in touch with the (political and social) needs at various levels of society. Intellectural leaders were important in Gramsci's scheme if they were able to express the 'feelings' of the oppressed groups (through intellectual and moral awareness).

The organic intellectuals, thus, associate themselves with popular culture. Mollica criticised observers looking from abroad who had generally failed to appreciate the commitment of Basaglia and colleagues to a redical transformation of the hegemonic practices in Italian society. Positions chosen by Psichiatria Democratica included: anti-empiricism (denying a neutral or apolitical role), the fight against social marginalisation and exclusion (emarginazione) and institutionalisation, and the need for deinstitutionalisation of the staff. The existence of illness was not denied but the reformers emphasised that any illness had to be considered in its social, political, and interpersonal context. The disasters of marginal status (emarginazione) and of chronicity constituting a 'second disease' were recognised. Mollica argues that Basaglia and colleagues such as G. Jervis, A. Pirella, S. Piro and A. Slavich accepted the responsibility expressed in Gramci's concept of the 'organicc intellectual'.

Mollica proceeds, in his paper, to describe the uneven process of implementation of the reform (following the passing of the national reform Law N. 180 of 1978). He then moves on to pointing out the failure to forge an overall professional coalition that would allow the full implementation of the reform and widespread cultural transformation within the entire profession (or professions) and the public mental health care system as a whole. It deserves mention that the group of psychiatrists (and psychologists) referred to as Psichiatria Democratica were intellectually diverse, and that there were theoretical and practical controversies (Basaglia et al., 1978; Setaro, 2024) with a joint, 'organic' position most clearly formulated during the early reform phase in Gorizia and expressed in the books 'Che cosè la psichiatria?' (Basaglia, 1967) and 'L'Istituzione negata' (Basaglia, 1968) and not necessarily persisting in all their further activities.

The organic intellectual: relevance today

Where current mental health recorm is concerned, it can be asked whether the concept of the 'organic intellectual' is still useful. A number of distinct and polarised viewpoints have been formulated by mental health professionals, e.g. concerning the total abolition of coercive measures, electroconvulsive treatment (ECT,) or the serotonin theory of depression (Moncrieff et al., 2023; Read et al., 2019; Zinkler & Peter, 2019). Such debates have received a mixed level of discussion in the wider public. In the UK, there has been substantial newspaper interest in Moncrieff's work on serotonin, considerable interest in ECT work (including doctors writing about their own experience of ECT, both for and against) and about mental health law.

The penetration of psychiatrists in mass media, in the UK, pales by comparison to Basaglia's (in the past). There is now much more in the way of media, including fragmentation. A reason for the loss of 'public profile' of mental health debates observed currently might be that Basaglia and his colleagues combined their specific psychiatric reform ambition with a vibrant political agenda, powerful images and societal movements and thus developed into organic intellectuals. In becoming organic intellectuals, they had to acknowledge their role and their limitations within a much

broader societal movement enabling a disruptive and fundamental change in the mental health care system by using and shaping the political agenda.

Any claim for organic intellectuals to reform current psychiatry using an agenda of the kind developed in the 1960s and 1970s needs to consider the 'Zeitgeist' around individualisation and economisation of the social sphere (Ehrenberg, 2014). As mental health professionals are rarely drivers of societal change it helps to develop strategies within the overall socal context according to the specific needs of the psychiatric reform agenda. Gaining political influence and media-related visibility by allying with interested national and regional policy makers and media professionals would be one way forward to facilitate mental health reform. What is equally important, and even more in line with the concept of the organic intellectual, is active solidarity and partisanship with social movements addressing social determinants of mental health such as minority status and poverty (Kirkbride et al., 2024) and/or the lived experience of people with mental illness.

Walter Benjamin, experience, service users and peer support

Walter Benjamin's discourse on experience and its being rooted in social and material life can help us think about some key issues relating to service user experience and participation within mental health services and beyond. Psychiatry and mental health practice and research have, in recent decades, experienced considerable conceptual change. There has been a surge in research on service user perspectives in both psychiatric practice and in wider mental health research (Åkerblom & Ness, 2023; Beresford, 2005; Chien et al., 2019; Lyons et al., 2021; Mahlke et al., 2017). Practice models have been presented, and peer support action programmes have been formulated (Gillard et al., 2015). Peer support models are effective in improving well-being, social functioning and recovery. It has been argued that the rise of the peer support model is related to

- the strength of a position of full participation in society that is owed every person with mental illness, and
- the full respect for personal autonomy extending to all persons afflicted by mental ill health.

This can be considered an accomplishment of the struggles fought in industrialised and postindustrial countries (and turned global through the efforts of activism and the World Health Organization).

There has, however, also been the argument that, in the peer involvement and peer support movement, there could be elements of a neo-liberal model of permanent self-improvement or self-reformulation as part of a neo-liberal 'Zeitgeist' (Braslow, 2013; Matuschek et al., 2023). The arguments around such innovative models point toward a 'non-psychiatric' formulation of the issues that are at stake. Peer-led resarch and peer support practices can be (and are often) implemented *within* the mental health system. However, such models and reseach activities could also focus on practical action and theoretical concepts *beyond* the mental health system. This fact points to wider social, cultural and political issues, and we could take interest in fields such as mad studies (Beresford & Rose, 2023) or subaltern studies (Zaib, 2015) which constitute neighbouring but related fields.

Walter Benjamin provides us with a conceptual, cultural science and philosophical framework that may help to better understand 'experience', beyond neoliberal 'consumer' or 'patient experience', in its relationship with the material social world. His work may also have provided a blueprint to understand how 'experience' evolves from the material background of 'remote or recent past'. Benjamin's speculative philosophy could, perhaps, also be the basis of innovative concepts relevant to 'madness' (see Morgan, this issue) and/or 'subaltern experience'.

From the 1960s onwards, there has been some influence of 'Critical Theory' on generic (and psychiatric) reform discourses. The idea of a body of theory enriched and strengthened through socially critical discourse based on detailed analyses (using 'critical consciousness') of societal reality was considered relevant (Jacob Taubes, according to Felsch (2024, p 38)). Criticism, according to this school of thought, implied self-reflection, and this was to be achieved through detailed economic, social and cultural science analyses. At the same time, the European psychiatric debate was influenced by the work of Michel Foucault who had related madness with the history of bourgeois reason (Vernunft). The idea of 'madness', in this analysis, was closely tied to Enlightenment's concept of 'reason'. Foucault had disenchanted the history of psychiatry (Heinze, 2008, p 420). A few decades earlier, during the Weimar Republic, a research group at the Institute of Social Research (in Frankfurt) had aimed to establish interdisciplinary social science research on a range of aspects of societal life. The scientists who, in retrospect, came to be called the 'Fankfurt School', intended to integrate the perspectives of specific scientific fields (e.g. sociology, geography, economics and psychology) to achieve a 'concrete (picture of) reality'

(Dubiel, 1992, p 19). This was based on the conviction that all individual scientific endeavour was embedded in an overall societal context. Michel Foucault (Foucault, 2008, p 1623), in an interview with Ducio Trombadori, stated that, had he known the work of the Frankfurt School, that could have saved him significant effort.

From critical theory to social critique and psychiatry

Referring to the Frankfurt School of 'critical theory' it was Max Horkheimer, head of the Frankfurt group, who wanted to juxtapose critical theory with what he called 'traditional theory'. What he meant was overcoming a 'positivist research paradigm' that, according to Horkheimer, would stick with 'Tatsachenforschung' (fact finding or factual research). Horkheimer intended social research to examine and scrutinise the 'given reality' using empirical findings, setting them in relation with 'reason' and 'theory' and bearing in mind the perspective of progress and societal emancipation. Crictical theory wanted to interrogate the socially 'given' rather than deal with an 'objective understanding' of isolated facts (Horkheimer, 1937). Getting science involved with societal conflict, of course, implied that the 'innocence' of the researcher was lost. This, of course, carried the risk of any scientific work stabilising the status quo (irrespective of its starting point and intention). This also applies to psychiatry. Economic drivers are of major relevance in the health sector. Health sector organisations and mental health trusts have interests, and psychiatric concepts such as treatment, healing and illness cannot be understood as 'pure' or innocent concepts. They are part of the wider societal arena and liable to (and always shaped by) social conflict.

Looking at the archive of the Fankfurt Institute of Social Reseach and, specifically, at the work of Walter Benjamin (who was part of the Institute group) can help us better understand elements of Frankfurt School thinking. Benjamin was a literary and cultural scientist, and he wrote his texts outside the academic system. However, there is a lot to be taken from Benjamin's reflection on institutions. In dealing with institutions Benjamin's interest was in the 'margins' or the 'exception to the rule' rather than the 'normal case' within the institutional set-up. He would argue that considering the 'margins' would help to better understand a 'structure'. To give an example of Benjamin's focus on the irregular rather than the rule, his texts on urban living (and the city) may be helpful: In thinking about cities, Benjamin said: 'Sich in einer Stadt nicht zurechtzufinden heißt nicht viel. In einer Stadt sich aber zu verirren, wie man in einem Walde sich verirrt, braucht Schulung'. (Not finding your way around a city doesn't mean much. But getting lost in a city, like getting lost in a forest, requires training; (Benjamin, 2010)). These words from Benjamin's text 'Berlin Childhood around 1900' indicate that what was noteworthy in an object or scenery, to Benjamin, was in no way an 'a priori' given. Any experience of 'truth', in his view, would arise only when all 'sense of security' had been lost (or cast aside). Concentrating on routine day-to-day practice will not contribute to moving closer to 'truth'. It is haphazard findings and unexpected occurrences that, for Benjamin, have the potential of irritating us. Thus, in 'One Way Street', he reflects on everyday phenomena such as 'construction site', 'petrol station', 'Frühstücksstube' (breakfast bar), 'Tiefbauarbeiten' (civil engineering work) or 'Uhren und Goldwaren' (watches and goldware) (Benjamin, 2001). For instance, the construction site, to Benjamin, is not about excavators or drills, but about a place in which the child is developing a 'sense of what building is'. Benjamin, however, goes beyond playing with words. His intention is to 'rid' objects of their usual function and context and to look at them so their 'secret' might come to the fore. His critical work is not about 'argument' but about 'description' or, in Benjamin's words, about 'literary montage'. He wrote that he had nothing to say, only 'to show' ('Nur zu zeigen.') Thus, the extensive use of uncommented 'quotation' assumes great importance in Walter Benjamin's writing. And this perspective might be useful in reflecting the lived experience of mental illness and its implications.

Turning to the profession, psychiatric practice requires categories, and it uses dimensions. Psychiatric practice needs to reflect deeper on what (and where) categories are useful. Psychiatry needs to take interest in what dictates current practice, whether it is the original human 'suffering' or 'need' or whether it is system-related factors or an external logic. One question is whether using 'dichotomy' (or category) is necessary or whether doing so carries the risk of losing focus. Walter Benjamin's thinking would strengthen such doubt. We argue that this kind of approach is pertinent to the current taxonomic and taxometric debates in psychiatry. A rising number of publications is exploring the advantages and disadvantages of 'dimensions over categories (Haslam et al., 2020) leading to novel diagnostic classification systems like the Hierarchical Taxonomy Of Psychopathology (HiTOP) (Kotov et al., 2018). Apart from diagnostic classification systems, dimensional thinking using continuum

beliefs is promising to reduce the stigma of mental illnesses (Peter et al., 2021), and it might be useful in defining social and individual responsibility with respect to substance use disorders (Schomerus & Speerforck, 2023). Turning back to mental health reform, it could be that such seemingly technical developments may carry some potential for 'silent' but powerful paradigm shifts in psychiatric diagnostic classification, in counselling and mental health care practice that are consonant with the broader background discussed in this paper. Without abandoning medical ideals or research and practice, indeed to properly strengthen them, we need to engage with, and allow ourselves to be led more, by those with experience of mental ill health conditions. And there is room for us, also, to align with wider social debates and struggles rather than retrench in the socially distant perspectives that our elite position in society constantly risks.

Disclosure statement

The authors declare that there is no conflict of interest.

Funding

No funding was received.

References

Acemoglu, D., & Restrepo, P. (2021). Tasks, automation, and the rise in US wage inequality. NBER Working Paper No. 28920, JEL No. J23,J31,O33. http://www.nber.org/papers/w28920

Åkerblom, K. B., & Ness, O. (2023). Peer workers in co-production and co-creation in mental health and substance use services: a scoping review. *Administration and Policy in Mental Health*, *50*(2), 296–316. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10488-022-01242-x

Anderson, P., & Jakubzik, F. (2018). *Hegemonie: Konjunkturen eines Begriffs* (1st ed.). Suhrkamp Verlag.

Basaglia, F. (a cura di). (1967). *Che cos'è la psichiatria?* Edito dalla Amministrazione Provinciale di Parma. Medicina Pratt, Parma.

Basaglia, F. (a cura di). (1968). *L'istituzione negata*. Einaudi.

Basaglia, F., & Basaglia-Ongaro, F. (1975/1980). *Befriedungsverbrechen. Über die Dienstbarkeit der Intellektuellen* [Crimini di Pace. Ricerche sugli intellettuali e sui tecnici come addetti all'oppressione]. Einaudi [Europäische Verlagsanstalt].

Basaglia, F., Ongaro Basaglia, F., Pirella, A., & Taverna, S. (1978). *La nave che affonda. Psichiatria e antipsichiatria a dieci anni da "L'istituzione negata": Un dibattito*. Editore Savelli.

Becker, T., & Fangerau, H. (2018). 40th birthday of the Italian Mental Health Law 180 - perception and reputation abroad, and a personal suggestion. *Epidemiology and Psychiatric Sciences*, *27*(4), 314–318. https://doi.org/10.1017/S2045796017000658

Becker, T., & Hoff, P. (this issue). Emil Kraepelin and Walter Benjamin: distant contemporaries, diverse working methods, any resonance? *International Review of Psychiatry*,

Benjamin, W. (2001). *Einbahnstraße*. Suhrkamp.

Benjamin, W. (2010). *Berliner Kindheit um neunzehnhundert*. Suhrkamp.

Benjamin, W. (Ed.), (1999). *The arcades project*. Belknap Press.

Beresford, P. (2005). Developing the theoretical basis for service user/survivor-led research and equal involvement in research. *Epidemiologia e Psichiatria Sociale*, *14*(1), 4–9. https://doi.org/10.1017/s1121189x0000186x

Beresford, P., & Rose, D. (2023). Decolonising global mental health: The role of Mad Studies. *Global Mental Health (Cambridge, England)*, *10*, e30. https://doi.org/10.1017/gmh.2023.21

Bhugra, D., Malik, A., Ikkos, G. (Eds.), (2011). *Psychiatry's contract with society: Concepts, controversies, and consequences*. Oxford University Press.

Braslow, J. T. (2013). The manufacture of recovery. *Annual Review of Clinical Psychology*, *9*(1), 781–809. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-clinpsy-050212-185642

Chien, W. T., Clifton, A. V., Zhao, S., & Lui, S. (2019). Peer support for people with schizophrenia or other serious mental illness. *The Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews*, *4*(4), CD010880. https://doi.org/10.1002/14651858.CD010880.pub2

Colucci, M., & Di Vittorio, P. (2001). *Franco Basaglia*. Bruno Mondadori.

Dubiel, H. (1992). *Kritische Theorie der Gesellschaft: Eine einführende Rekonstruktion von den Anfängen im Horkheimer-Kreis bis Habermas* (2nd ed.). Juventa-Verl.

Ehrenberg, A. (2014). *Das erschöpfte Selbst: Depression und Gesellschaft in der Gegenwart* (2nd ed.). Campus Frankfurt.

Felsch, P. (2024). *Der Philosoph: Habermas und wir: ein neuer Blick auf einen der weltweit einflussreichsten Intellektuellen der Nachkriegszeit*. Propyläen Verlag.

Fontana, B. (1993). *Hegemony and power: On the relation between Gramsci and Machiavelli*. University of Minnesota Press.

Foot, J. (2015). *The man who closed the asylums: Franco Basaglia and the revolution in mental health care*., 1st ed. Verso.

Forgacs, D. (Ed.), (2000). *The Gramsci reader: Selected writings, 1916-1935*. New York University Press.

Foucault, M. (2008). *Die Hauptwerke* (1st ed.). Suhrkamp.

Francese, J. (Ed.), (2009). *Perspectives on Gramsci: Politics, culture and social theory*. Routledge.

Gillard, S., Gibson, S. L., Holley, J., & Lucock, M. (2015). Developing a change model for peer worker interventions in mental health services: a qualitative research study. *Epidemiology and Psychiatric Sciences*, *24*(5), 435–445. https://doi.org/10.1017/S2045796014000407

Goffman, E. (1990). *Asylums: Essays on the social situation of mental patients and other immates* (1st ed.) Anchor Books.

Haslam, N., McGrath, M. J., Viechtbauer, W., & Kuppens, P. (2020). Dimensions over categories: a meta-analysis of taxometric research. *Psychological Medicine*, *50*(9), 1418–1432. https://doi.org/10.1017/S003329172000183X

Haug, W. F. (2017). *Kritik der Warenästhetik* (3rd ed.). Suhrkamp.

Heinze, M. (2008). Psychiatrie. In C. Kammler, R. Parr, & U. J. Schneider, (Eds.), *Foucault-Handbuch. Leben - Werk - Wirkung* (1st ed., pp. 417–426). J.B. Metzler'sche Verlagsbuchhandlung und Carl Ernst Poeschel Verlag GmbH.

Horkheimer, M. (1937). Traditionelle und kritische Theorie. *Zeitschrift Für Sozialforschung*, *6*(2), 245–294. https://doi.org/10.5840/zfs19376265

Ikkos, G., & Stanghellini, G. (this issue). History, "Nowtime" (Jetztzeit) and Dialectical Images: Introduction to Walter Benjamin for Psychiatry (I). *International Review of Psychiatry*,

Kirkbride, J. B., Anglin, D. M., Colman, I., Dykxhoorn, J., Jones, P. B., Patalay, P., Pitman, A., Soneson, E., Steare, T., Wright, T., & Griffiths, S. L. (2024). The social determinants of mental health and disorder: evidence, prevention and recommendations. *World Psychiatry: official Journal of the World Psychiatric Association (WPA)*, *23*(1), 58–90. https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.21160

Kotov, R., Krueger, R. F., & Watson, D. (2018). A paradigm shift in psychiatric classification: the Hierarchical Taxonomy Of Psychopathology (HiTOP). *World Psychiatry: official Journal of the World Psychiatric Association (WPA)*, *17*(1), 24–25. https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.20478

Leoni, F. (a cura di). (2011). *Franco Basaglia: Un laboratorio italiano*. Bruno Mondadori.

Loheit, J. (2019). Benjamins Material. Oder der Stoff, aus dem die Wunschbilder sind. In F. Voigt, N. Tzanakis Papadakis, J. Loheit, & K. Baehrens (Eds.), *Material und Begriff. Arbeitsverfahren und theoretische Beziehungen Walter Benjamins* (pp. 261–284). Argument.

Lumley, R. (1983). States of emergency: Cultures of revolt in Italy from 1968 to 1978. https://files.libcom.org/files/Robert%20Lumley-%20States%20of%20emergency%3B%20Cultures%20of%20revolt%20in%20Italy%20from%201968%20to%201978.pdf

Lyons, N., Cooper, C., & Lloyd-Evans, B. (2021). A systematic review and meta-analysis of group peer support interventions for people experiencing mental health conditions. *BMC Psychiatry*, *21*(1), 315. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12888-021-03321-z

Mahlke, C. I., Priebe, S., Heumann, K., Daubmann, A., Wegscheider, K., & Bock, T. (2017). Effectiveness of one-to-one peer support for patients with severe mental illness - a randomised controlled trial. *European Psychiatry*, *42*, 103–110. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2016.12.007

Matuschek, I., Angermeyer, M., & Schomerus, G. (2023). Die Ökonomisierung des Sozialen und der Zwang zur Selbstoptimierung – Implikationen für die Einstellungen der Bevölkerung zu Menschen mit Schizophrenie. *Psychiatrische Praxis*, *50*(5), 274–278. https://doi.org/10.1055/a-1855-9587

Meiffert, T. (2017). Die mikrologische Regel der Wahrheit. Anmerkungen zur Methode Walter Benjamins. https://www.academia.edu/33518684/Die_mikrologische_Regel_der_Wahrheit_Anmerkungen_zur_Methode_Walter_Benjamins

Mollica, R. F. (1985). From Antonio Gramsci to Franco Basaglia: the theory and practice of the Italian psychiatric reform. *International Journal of Mental Health*, *14*(1-2), 22–41. https://doi.org/10.1080/00207411.1985.11448986

Moncrieff, J., Cooper, R. E., Stockmann, T., Amendola, S., Hengartner, M. P., & Horowitz, M. A. (2023). The serotonin theory of depression: a systematic umbrella review of the evidence. *Molecular Psychiatry*, *28*(8), 3243–3256. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41380-022-01661-0

Morgan, A. (this issue). "… the most complex and lyrical song of experience": Walter Benjamin and a dialectical image of madness. Introduction to Walter Benjamin for psychiatry (III). *International Review of Psychiatry*,

Peloso, P. F. (2023). *Franco Basaglia, un profilo. Dalla critica dell'istituzione psichiatrica alla critica della società*. Carocci.

Peter, L.-J., Schindler, S., Sander, C., Schmidt, S., Muehlan, H., McLaren, T., Tomczyk, S., Speerforck, S., & Schomerus, G. (2021). Continuum beliefs and mental illness stigma: a systematic review and meta-analysis of correlation and intervention studies. *Psychological Medicine*, *51*(5), 716–726. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0033291721000854

Pieraccini, L. (a cura di), (2006). Ernesto de Martino e Franco Basaglia: la riflessione su identità/alterità. Il de Martino. *Rivista Dell'Istituo Ernesto de Martino*, *18*(6), 1–120.

Pizzolato, N., Holst, J. D. (Eds.). (2017). *Antonio Gramsci*. Springer International Publishing.

Ramos, V. (1982). The concepts of ideology, hegemony, and organic intellectuals in Gramsci's marxism. *Theoretical Review*, *30*(3-8), 34.

Read, J., Cunliffe, S., Jauhar, S., & McLoughlin, D. M. (2019). Should we stop using electroconvulsive therapy? *BMJ (Clinical Research ed.)*, *364*, k5233. https://doi.org/10.1136/bmj.k5233

Schomerus, G., & Speerforck, S. (2023). Suchtbehandlung ohne Schuldzuschreibung – eine Utopie? *Psychiatrische Praxis*, *50*(4), 175–177. https://doi.org/10.1055/a-2063-0747

Setaro, M. (a cura di). (2024). *Fare l'impossibile. Ragionando di psichiatria e potere*. Editore Donzelli.

Spivak, G. C. (1988). Can the subaltern speak? In C. Nelson (Ed.), *Marxism and the interpretation of culture* (8th ed., pp. 66–111). Univ. of Illinois Press.

Voigt, F., Tzanakis Papadakis, N., Loheit, J., Baehrens, K. (Eds.), (2019). *Material und Begriff: Arbeitsverfahren und theoretische Beziehungen Walter Benjamins*. Argument.

Weber, M. (2015). *Wissenschaft als Beruf*. Reclam.

Weber, M. (2018). *Politik als Beruf*. Reclam.

Weiss, K. J. (2011). Asylum reform and the great comeuppance of 1894–or was it? *The Journal of Nervous and Mental Disease*, *199*(9), 631–638. https://doi.org/10.1097/NMD.0b013e318229ce94

Zaib, S. (2015). Subaltern studies. In J. Preto Meirinhos, M. Lobato, de M. Deus Manso, P. Bacelar de Vasconselos, J. Widodo, A. Alves, J. Sik Shin, W.-H. Kim, W. Wei-Kuo Lin, L. Lavanchawee, F. Cardoso Gomes, D. Richard, K. D. Jackson, & R. E. Xavier (Eds.), *Quality of life* (pp. 213–223). EWIAS Viewpoints.

Zinkler, M., & Peter, S. V (2019). Ohne Zwang – ein Konzept für eine ausschließlich unterstützende Psychiatrie. *Recht & Psychiatrie*, *37*, 203–209.